

Sweet potato and black bean burger with roasted yellow pepper sauce

These gourmand burgers have a rich, interesting flavor; the cornmeal gives them a beautiful **crispy** coating. I would have to say that of all the recipes in this book, this burger stands out as my signature dish. The recipe combines an extremely nutritious yet diverse selection of ingredients. The sweet and savory flavors make a triumphant blend. The number-one choice to top these burgers can only be Roasted Yellow Pepper Sauce (page 100); the flavors and colors shine together.

Shortly after graduating from cooking school, I made this dish whenever I cooked for family or friends. My parents were hooked immediately, which of course obligated me to make them every time I saw them. Which then encouraged me to start thinking of new recipes. And so a book was born.

1 medium onion, finely chopped

1½ tablespoons olive oil

3 garlic cloves, minced

1 carrot, peeled and finely grated

2 cups cooked black beans [330g]

½ ounce dried shiitake mushrooms, soaked in hot water until soft, stemmed, caps coarsely chopped [15g]

2 tablespoons tomato paste

1 teaspoon salt

¼ teaspoon freshly ground pepper

½ cup peeled and mashed cooked sweet potato [120g]

1 cup cooked quinoa [160g]*

1 tablespoon caraway seeds

3 tablespoons chopped cilantro

1 teaspoon hot sauce and/or 1 tablespoon vegetarian Worcestershire sauce

1 tablespoon balsamic vinegar

1½ to 2 cups dried bread crumbs [100 to 140g]

1 cup coarse ground cornmeal [125g]

½ cup safflower or canola oil, for frying [125ml]

1. In a large skillet, **cook** the onion in the olive oil over medium heat until soft and nicely browned, 7 to 10 minutes. Add the garlic, carrot, black beans, and mushrooms to the pan and cook for 2 to 3 minutes, stirring occasionally, until the garlic is softened and fragrant.
2. Remove from the heat. With a potato masher or large fork, **mash** until the beans are about half crushed. Stir in the tomato paste. Season with the salt and pepper.
3. Place the bean mixture in a large bowl. **Add** the sweet potato, quinoa, caraway seeds, and cilantro. Mix thoroughly. Season with hot sauce and/or Worcestershire sauce, vinegar, and additional salt and pepper to taste. Gradually add enough bread crumbs to produce a mixture firm enough to hold together. Let cool.
4. **Form** the bean mixture into 8 burgers about 3 inches [8cm] in diameter. Spread out the cornmeal on a clean plate.
5. One at a time, **dredge** the burgers in the cornmeal, using your hands to carefully coat both sides. Place on another plate or clean surface. Finish all 8 burgers and set aside. Use extra cornmeal, if necessary, to coat them all.
6. In a large skillet, heat ¼ cup [60ml] of the oil over medium-high heat. When the oil begins to shimmer, add 3 or 4 of the burgers and **fry**, turning once with a wide spatula, holding a second spatula perpendicular to the burger to “catch” it and let the burger down easy on the other side. (This prevents splashing.) Cook until crispy and brown outside and heated through, about 2 minutes per side. Add the remaining oil and, when it returns to temperature, cook the remaining burgers. Drain on paper towels. Serve with Roasted Yellow Pepper Sauce.

MAKES 8 BURGERS

*Quinoa (pronounced KEEN-wah) is called a super-grain because of its nutritious qualities. It is extremely high in protein and cooks in just about 15 minutes. To end up with 1 cup cooked quinoa, start with ⅓ cup [60g] raw.